IDENTITY THEORY VS. SOCIAL IDENTITY THEORY



The Self & Social Identities

Organize yourselves into groups based on something you think you have in common.

You Have 90 Seconds to Form Groups.

How did you decide the category?

Could you have grouped yourselves completely differently?

Did you immediately notice who was “us” versus “not us”?

What does this tell us about how social identities form?



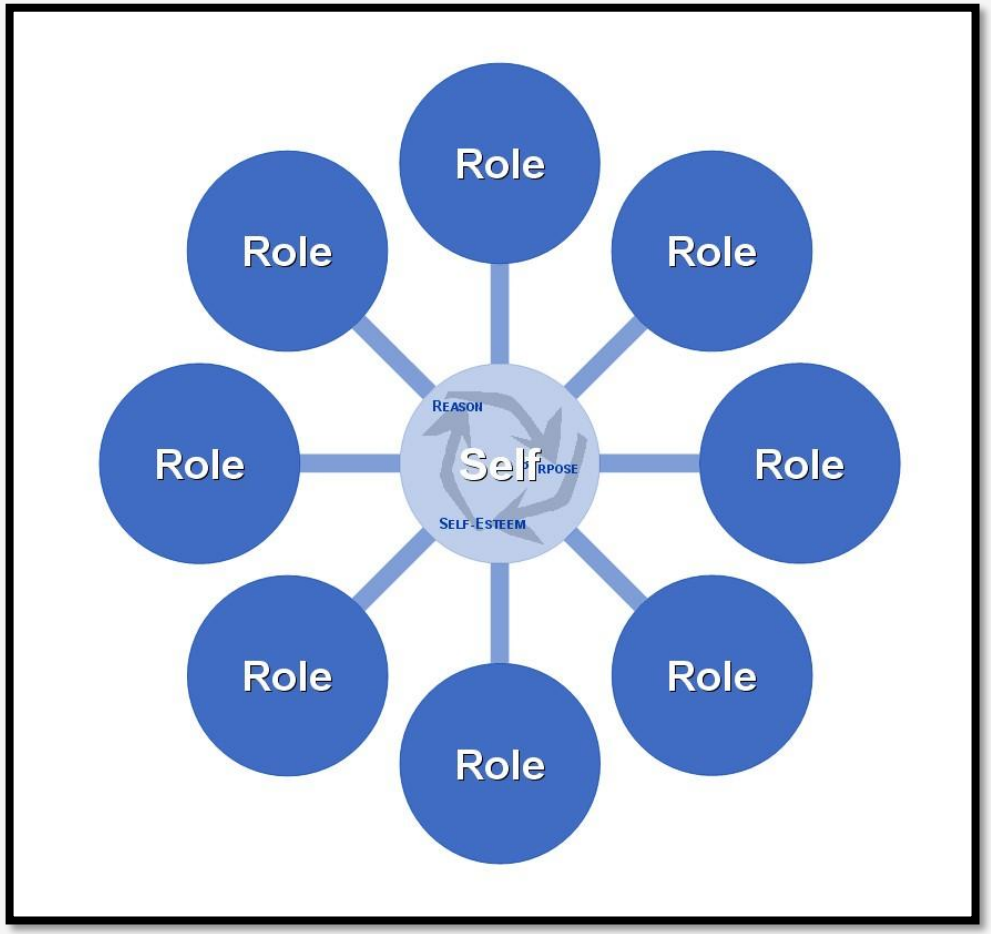
Identity Theory vs. Social Identity Theory

- Two perspectives on the social basis of the self-concept and on the nature of normative behavior
- Describes "the self" as defined by society
- Both regard the self as differentiated into separate, multiple identities

Identity Theory

- Identity theory explains social behavior in terms of the reciprocal relations between the self and one's society

- The self therefore is defined through organized roles which forms role identities

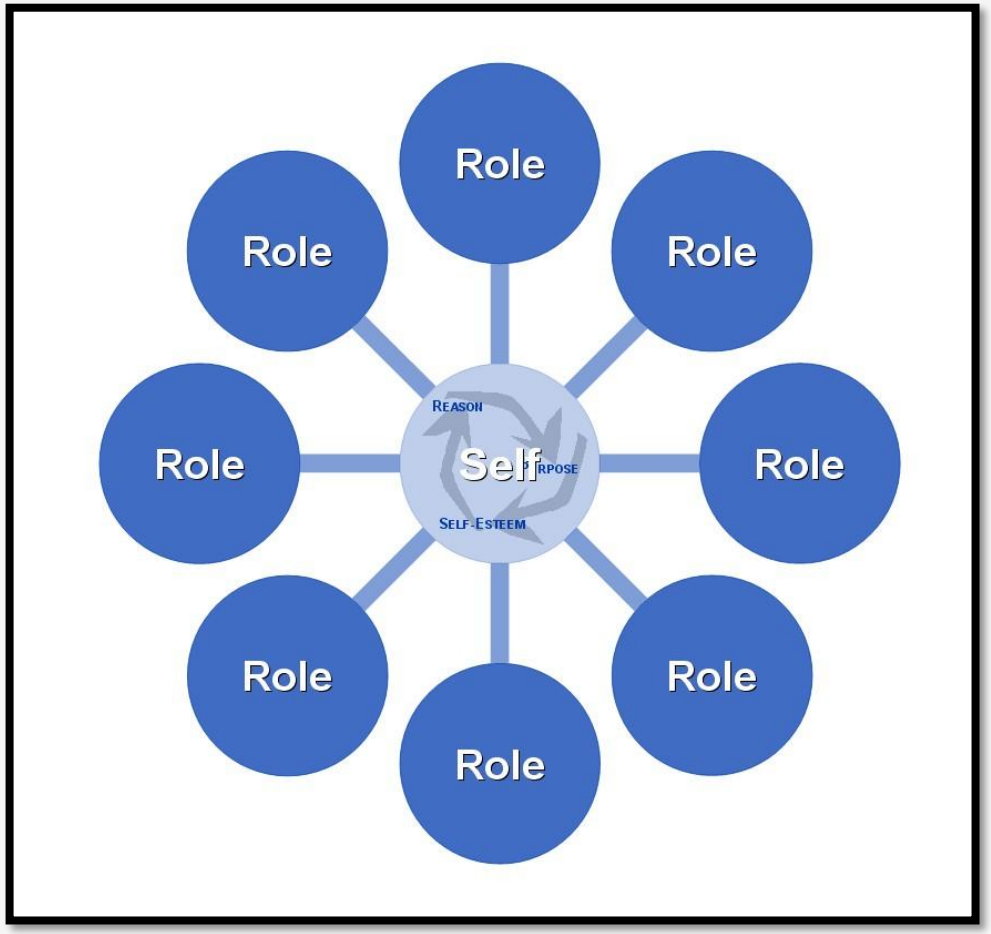


Identity Theory

- Role identities are organized hierarchically in the self, with some roles more likely to be activated than others

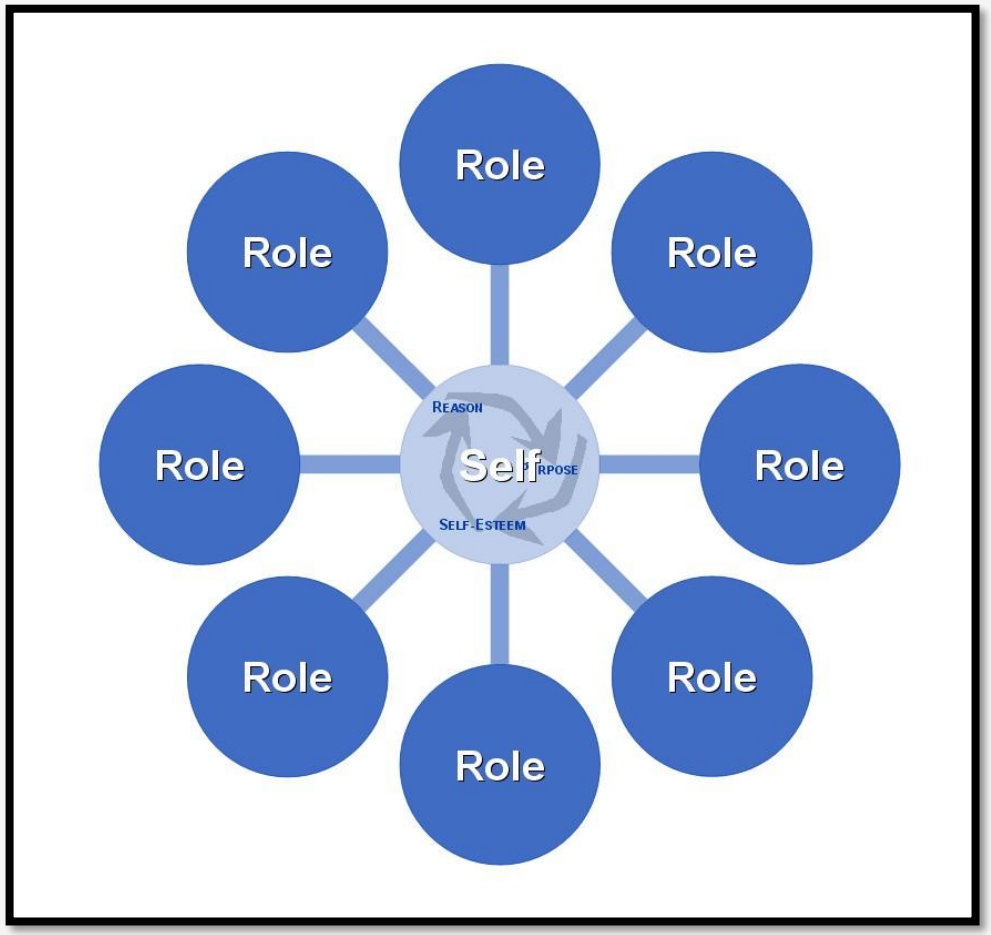
- <u>One proposal:</u> salient identities are associated with positive evaluations of others who occupy the same role

- <u>Another proposal:</u> the importance of social relationships for a particular role may influence the identity salience



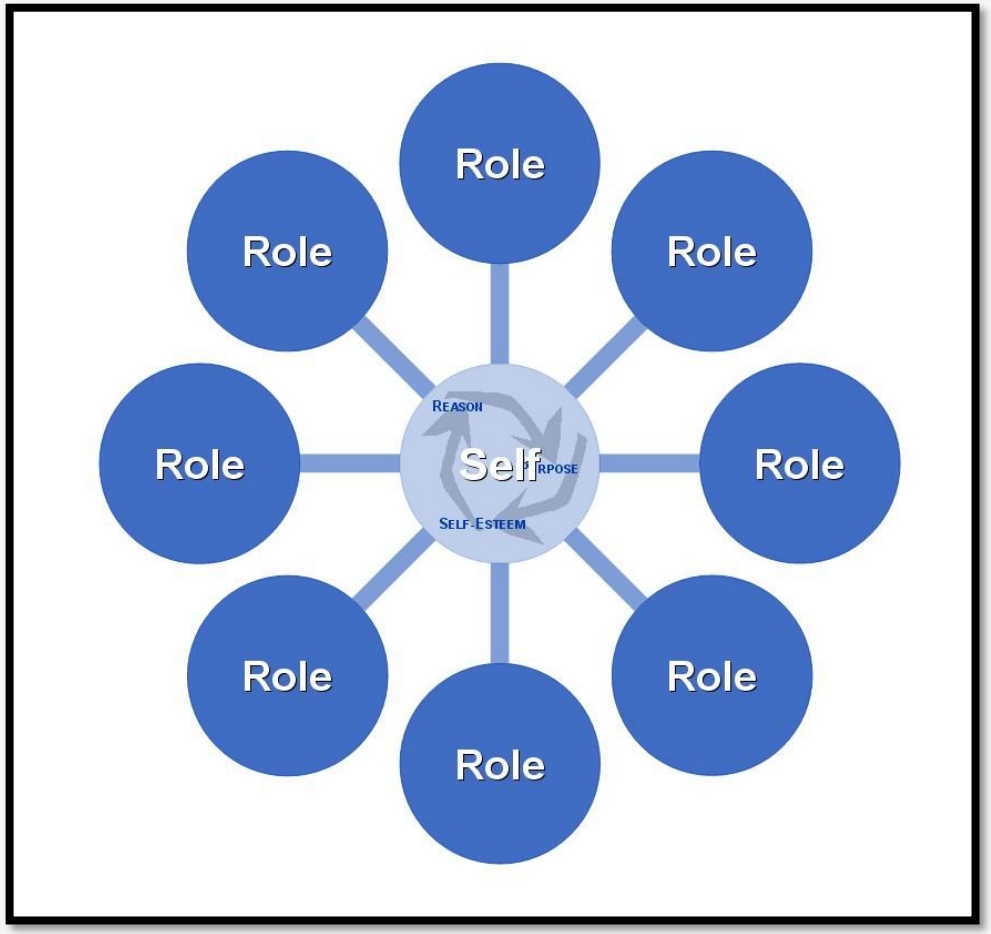
Identity Theory

- <u>Central characteristics of identity theory:</u>
  - 1) Social factors define the self
  - 2) The social nature of the self is conceived from the roles people occupy
  - 3) Role identities vary in their salience
  - 4) The impact of role identities on relations with others has not been an important focus



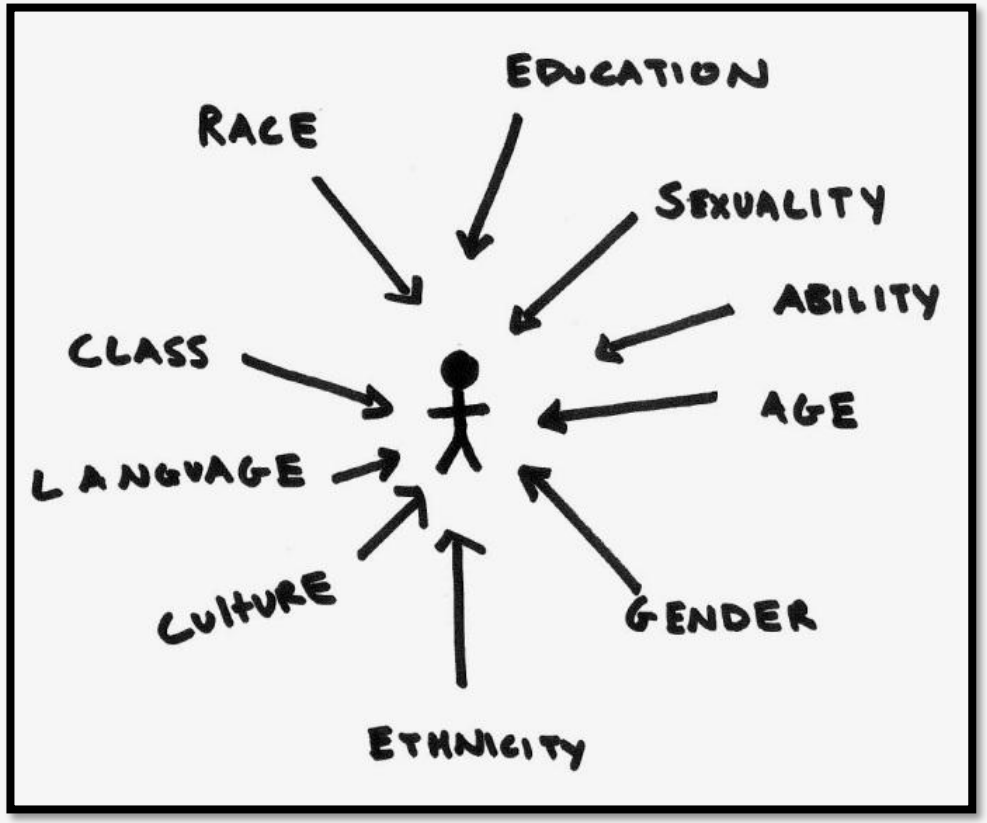
Thoughts on Identity Theory?

- What do you think this theory is missing or not capturing?
- What identity experiences do you think it defines well?



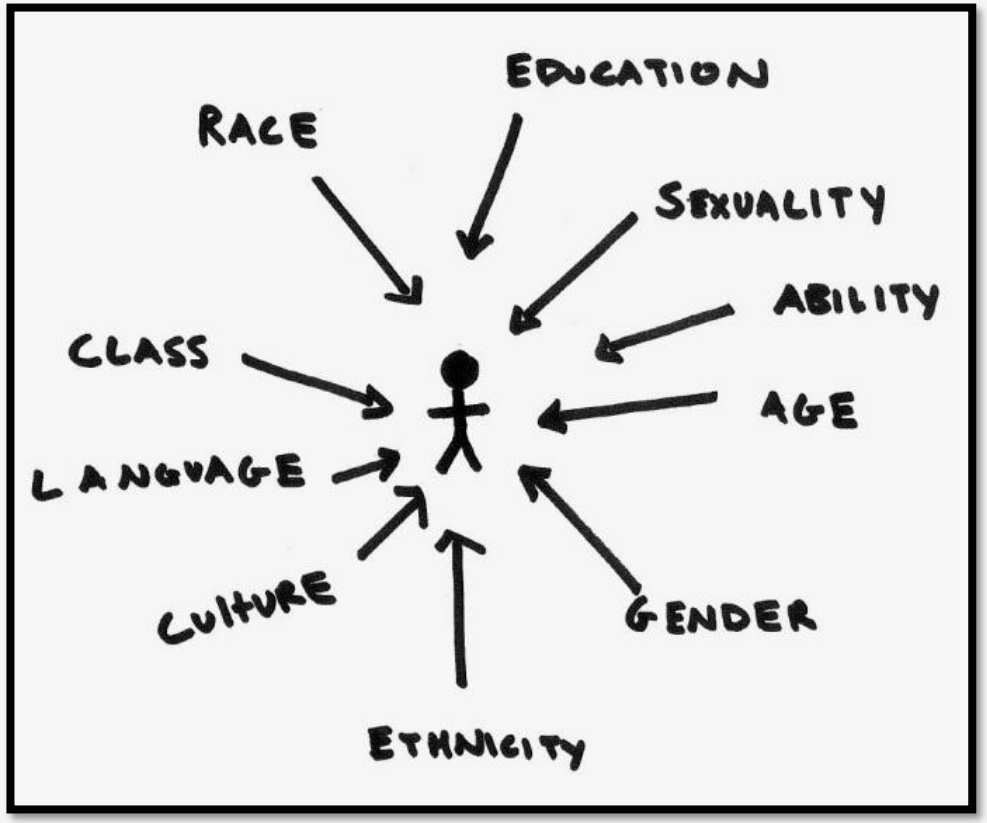
Social Identity Theory

- <u>Social identity theory:</u> a social psychological theory of intergroup relations and the self
- A social category (e.g., nationality, political affiliation, sports team) into which one feels belonging, provides a definition of who one is
- When a social identity is salient, perceptions for ingroup/outgroup norms are activated



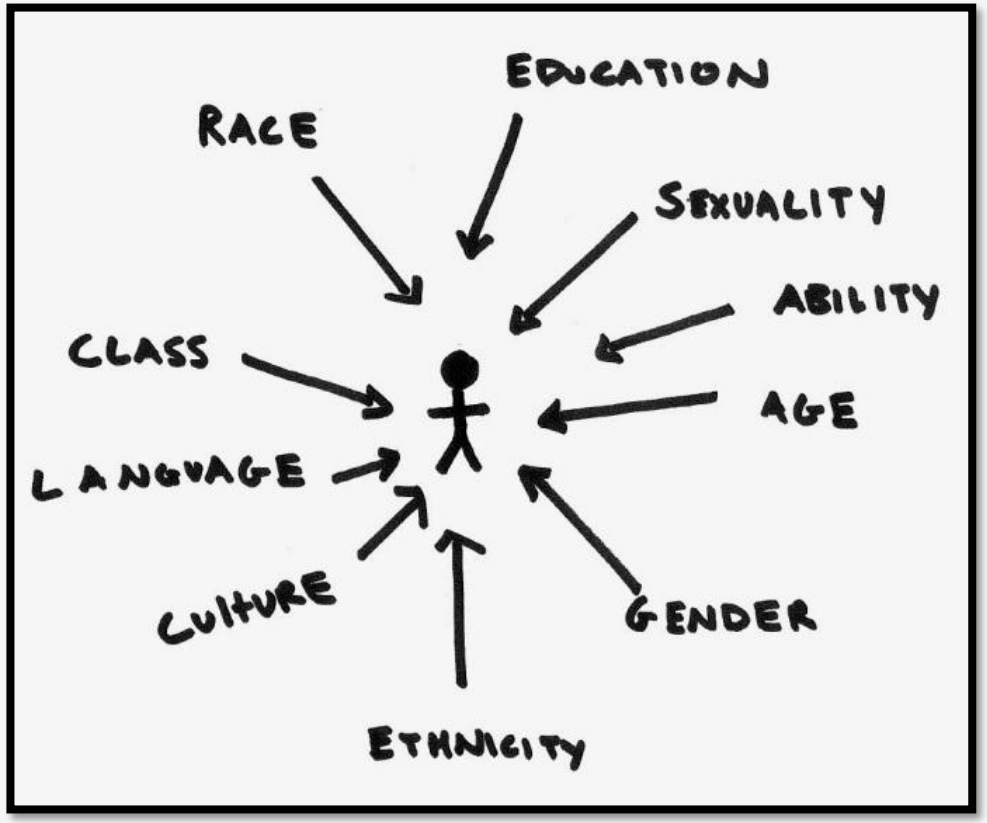
Social Identity Theory

- Social identities are also evaluative of a social category, and thus of its group members
- We are strongly motivated to adopt behavioral strategies to maintain and protect our ingroups
- Constant ingroup/outgroup comparisons



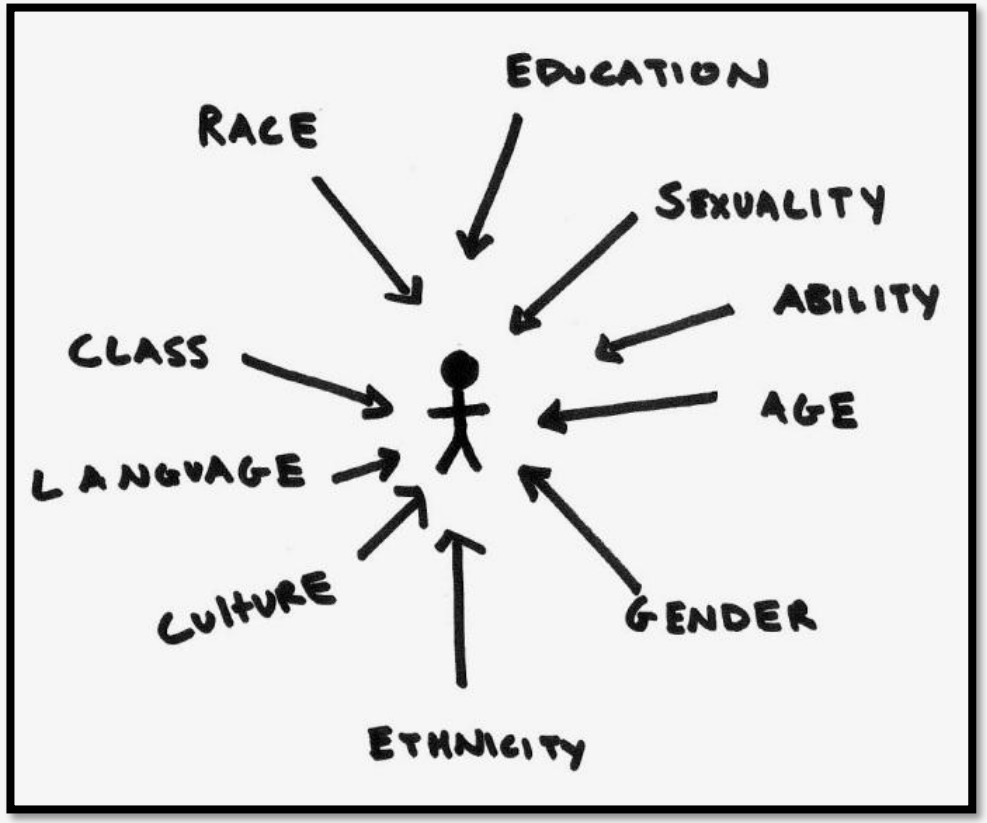
Social Identity Theory

- Social identity theory invokes two processes:
  - 1) Self-Categorization: sharpens intergroup boundaries by producing group-distinctive stereotypical and normative perceptions
  - 2) Self-Enhancement: guides the social categorization process such that ingroup norms largely favor the ingroup



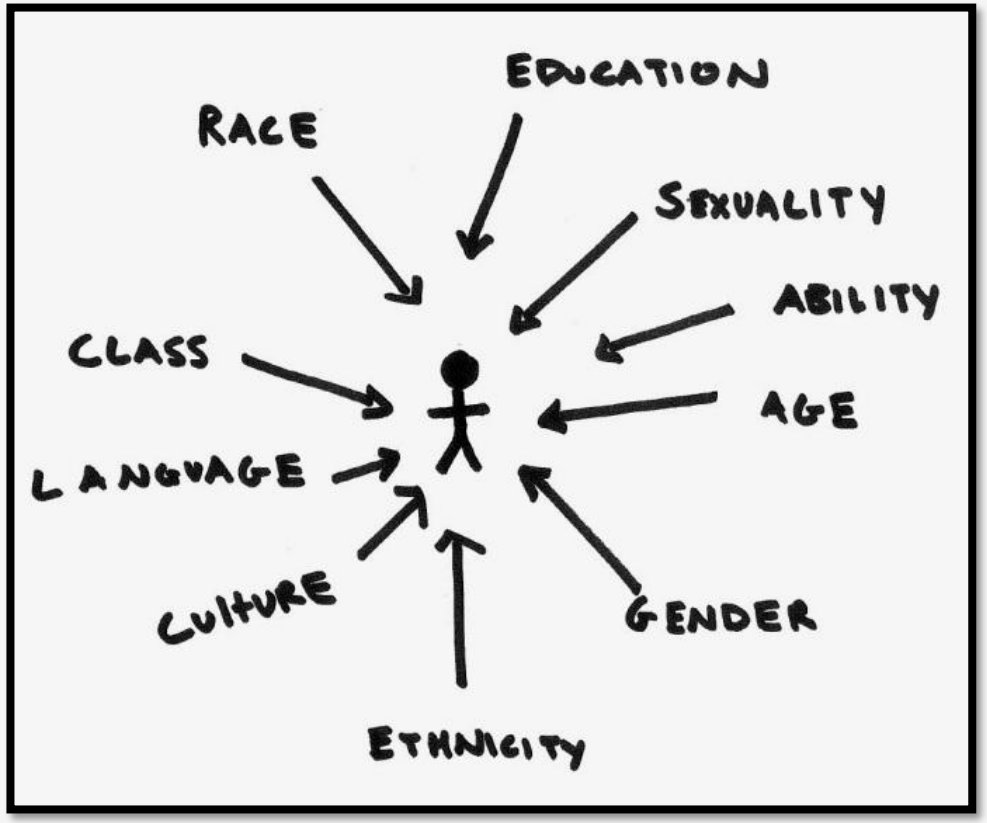
Social Identity Theory

- <u>Central traits of social identity theory:</u>
  - 1) Based on social group membership
  - 2) It incorporates both the immediate and the more enduring intergroup context
  - 3) It accounts for the range of group behaviors (e.g., conformity, discrimination)
  - 4) It is both social and cognitive and provides group membership meaning



Thoughts on Social Identity Theory?

- What do you think this theory is missing or not capturing?
- What identity experiences do you think it defines well?



Similarities Between Theories

- **Both address the structure of the socially constructed self (called identity or social identity)**
- **Both consider behavior to be organized into meaningful units: identity theory in terms of roles and social identity theory in terms of group norms**
- **Both discuss the way identities are internalized and define the self: identity theory labels oneself as a member of a social role, social identity theory speaks of self-categorization into a group**





Differences Between Theories

- <u>Identity theory addresses:</u>
  - counter roles such as father-daughter
  - views identity as stable and highlights identity salience
  - sociology approaches and no cognitive processes
  - the possibility of role ingroup favoritism



- <u>Social identity theory addresses:</u>
  - intergroup relations and the role of outgroups
  - views identity as more dynamic and context based
  - links between identity to cognition and behavior
  - ingroup/outgroup distinctions as it relates to self-esteem



Which Theory Wins?

DUKE STUDENT

A.Identity Theory

B. Social Identity Theory

C. Both

D. Neither



Which Theory Wins?

Older Sister

A.Identity Theory

B. Social Identity Theory

C. Both

D. Neither



Which Theory Wins?

Runner

A.Identity Theory

B. Social Identity Theory

C. Both

D. Neither



Pick ONE of your identities.

Discuss in small groups.

1. How would Identity Theory explain it?

What role do you occupy? What behaviors are expected of you?

2. How would Social Identity Theory explain it?

What group does it connect you to? Who becomes "us"? Who becomes "them"?

3. Which theory explains your experience better—and what does the other theory miss?

Next Class…

Social Belonging & Groups, Questions Due Monday @ 2pm!

Writing Studio Visit Tuesday

Paper 1 Introduced Thursday

